

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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The Tabernacle

The tabernacle was a portable sanctuary where God lived among the Israelite people. From the beginning of creation, God's plan was to share his life with humans and allow people to have a close relationship with him. However, when sin entered the world, it created a serious problem (Genesis 3). If sinful people were to come into God's presence, God's holiness would destroy them.

The tabernacle provided a temporary solution to this problem. It was a special structure like a tent that allowed the Israelites to enjoy God's presence without being destroyed by it (Exodus 25:8). It served as a mobile place of worship where Israel offered sacrifices to God and worshiped him.

The tabernacle shows us what is necessary to enter God's presence:

- The altar shows that sin must be removed through a sacrificial death. This was a large bronze structure where animals were sacrificed to pay for people's sins.
- The washbasin shows that having a relationship with God requires removing uncleanness—anything that goes against God's perfect moral standards. This was a large bronze bowl filled with water where priests washed their hands and feet before serving in the tabernacle.
- In the Holy Place, the lampstand and the table show that we must walk in God's light and depend on him to provide what we need. The golden lampstand had seven branches and provided the only light in the Holy Place, while the table held twelve loaves of bread representing God's provision for the twelve tribes of Israel.
- The incense altar represents prayer. The constantly rising incense reminds those who are forgiven and clean, who follow God's guidance and depend on him, that they have complete access to him. This small golden altar stood just before the curtain to the Most Holy Place, and priests burned sweet-smelling incense on it daily.
- The curtain between the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place reminds us that the Almighty, the holy God who invites us into fellowship, must not be approached carelessly. This thick, colorful veil separated the two rooms and protected people from God's direct presence.
- Behind the curtain is the ark of the covenant, over which God's glory appeared. This symbolized God's

rule as Israel's king. The central position of the ark reflects God's main purpose for his people—a covenant relationship with the living God. The ark was a gold-covered wooden chest containing the stone tablets of the Ten Commandments, Aaron's rod, and a jar of manna.

Our new covenant relationship with God is possible because of Jesus' perfect sacrifice for sin and his role as our high priest before God (see especially Hebrews 9–10). He has fulfilled the requirements shown by the ancient tabernacle. We can now approach God's throne with courage and confidence (see Ephesians 3:12; Hebrews 4:14–16).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 25:1–9; 26:1–37; 35:4–36:38; 38:21–31; 39:32–40:35; 2 Chronicles 3:1–7:22; Hebrews 9:1–28

Temple Design as a Picture of God's Truth

The temple plan in Ezekiel 40–43 does not seem possible to build, nor was it meant to be. The plan lacks enough detail for construction, as shown by the different diagrams scholars have created. Unlike the tabernacle, the plan does not specify materials (Exodus 25:10–40:33). There is also no evidence that anyone tried to build the second temple using this plan. Therefore, Ezekiel's temple plan is not a blueprint for future construction.

Ezekiel's temple vision shows God's message through a building design. It intends to shame Ezekiel's generation for their past and encourage future faithfulness (Ezekiel 43:10–12). The vision describes a new world where obvious boundaries between the holy and unholy exist, and standards are higher. This allows God to return to his temple and live among his people again (see 10:3–4, 18; 11:22–23).

Access to the holy area is much more limited. Faithful individuals from the past gain renewed access, while God rejects unfaithful people. There is a stronger focus on sacrifices for atonement and purification for the people.

This new temple represents Jesus Christ, who reveals God's glory. His body was a temple that others would destroy and he would rebuild in three days (John 2:19). In Jesus, God's holiness shone brightly in the darkness, and the darkness could not overcome it (John 1:5). His body was the perfect, one-time sacrifice that purified the people (Hebrews 10:12).

Those united to Christ now have the privilege of accessing the Most Holy Place in heaven in the new Jerusalem. Its doors are always open to those who

“have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb” (see Revelation 21; 22:14).

Since God unites us Christians with Christ and we are part of his body, the new temple, we cannot live as we did before. The Holy Spirit lives in and among us, and our bodies now belong to him as parts of his new temple (1 Corinthians 6:15–20). A holy life is proof that we are God’s children (1 Peter 1:13–16).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 25:10–40:33; Leviticus 10:9–11; Ezekiel 22:26; 40:1–43:27; John 2:19; 1 Corinthians 6:15–20; Hebrews 9:22–10:19; 1 Peter 1:13–16; Revelation 21:1–27

Temple Legislation as Theology

The religious teachers of Judaism (called “rabbis”) spent much time trying to make the laws of Ezekiel 44–48 agree with those laws of the Torah (the law given to Moses). They failed because these chapters do not intend to match the law of Moses. This is similar to how the vision of the temple building was not designed to look like the tabernacle or Solomon’s Temple (Ezekiel 40–43). The temple rules describe a theological message of change, similar to the earlier description of the temple’s architecture.

These rules emphasized the need to separate the temple from the palace. Sacrificial ceremonies would increase and focus more on purification. Holy people would again make offerings to the holy God. These practices intended to separate the holy from the unholy and purify God’s people. Pollution of the temple and idol worship had caused the Lord to leave (Ezekiel 8–11).

So, they needed a new situation for God to live among his people again. These rules intended to make the prophet’s listeners aware of their past wrongs that confused what was holy and unholy. It also encouraged them that God would restore their worship to its proper condition.

These rules also put the prince, the king descended from King David, in a position of submission to the Lord. The arrival of Jesus fulfills this element. Jesus came as a servant king who was happy to do what the Father wanted (Matthew 4:1–11; 20:25–28). He offered the perfect sacrifice that cleanses sin, purified the heavenly sanctuary once for all time, and ensured that God could live among his people forever (Hebrews 9:11–12, 23). His blood cleanses us from all sin. It allows sinners to confidently enter most holy place of heaven without fear of rejection or punishment.

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 56:7; Ezekiel 8:1–11:25; 40:1–43:27; 44:1–46:18

Temple Worship

In the ancient Near East, kings had to provide for their nation’s temple. King David, who started the family line (dynasty) of Judah’s kings, made Jerusalem the capital of Israel (2 Samuel 5:4–10). He also made it the main place of worship. King Solomon built the temple, but David prepared for its construction and worship practices.

Solomon took seven years to build the temple in Jerusalem. He started in the fourth year of his rule (967 BC). The temple was large. It was 27 meters long (90 feet), 9 meters wide (30 feet), and almost 13 meters high (45 feet). Its entrance court (portico or vestibule) was 4.5 meters deep (15 feet), spanning the width (see 1 Kings 6:2–10).

He used the most advanced building techniques of the time. The cost was not a concern for construction, decoration, or equipment. Even so, Solomon admitted it was not good enough to house the eternal God (1 Kings 8:27).

The temple, next to the king’s palace, represented God’s rule over creation and all nations. “The LORD is in His holy temple; let all the earth be silent before Him” (Habakkuk 2:20). It taught Israel about God’s unique rule and their complete reliance on him. Although no building can contain God, he chose the temple as the main place for his presence on earth. Thus, the temple was central to Israelite worship and the personal relationship between God and his people.

God gave the kings the task of committing themselves to him and promoting proper worship at the temple. The temple confirmed that God authorized the human king to represent divine rule. Psalm 132 expressed this role by celebrating David’s return of the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem (Psalm 132:6–12). Solomon used this psalm at the end of his prayer when he established the temple (2 Chronicles 6:41–42).

Later, Christ and the church fulfilled the temple’s role in showing God’s presence. Jesus indicated the shift from the temple buildings to his own body as the spiritual temple (see John 2:19). The disciples began to understand this change after Christ’s resurrection (John 2:21–22).

The apostle Paul described the church as the new holy space where Jews and non-Jews (gentiles) are reconciled. Using temple imagery, he explained how Jesus “has torn down the dividing wall of hostility” in the body of Christ (the church) to create one people (Ephesians 2:14–15). The church is God’s holy

temple, built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets (Ephesians 2:20–22). It is made from “living stones,” Christians, who God joins together around Jesus Christ, the cornerstone (1 Peter 2:4–5).

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 8:27–53; 1 Chronicles 22:1–19; 2 Chronicles 5:2–14; 6:41–42; 7:12–16; Psalm 48:9; 65:4; 66:13; 138:2; Jeremiah 7:3–11; 11:15; Ezekiel 8:6–16; 44:1–31; Joel 1:14; 2:17; Habakkuk 2:20; Haggai 2:7; John 2:19–22; Ephesians 2:14–15, 20–22; 1 Peter 2:4–5

The Theater and Revelation

In the ancient world, theater was a form of storytelling through live performances with actors, scenes, and dramatic presentations. Understanding the way ancient performances worked can help us understand Revelation 4–5. These chapters introduce a divine drama (like a play with scenes and actors) and show the importance of God’s agent (the Messiah) in world history. This passage prepares the reader for the main message of the book, which is about the world, the reality of judgment, and the victory that comes through the Lamb (Jesus). In these chapters, a series of scenes (like in a play) is used to communicate the message.

Revelation 4:1–3 begins by describing God on his heavenly throne. In ancient theater, a person representing a god sat in a central box or throne high above the stage. This actor explained each scene’s importance to the audience with positive and negative comments. Or he resolved script problems too complex for the characters. Similarly, readers of Revelation should look for scenes where God or his messengers interpret or interrupt to explain the message.

The ancient drama developed on the stage beneath the divine figure. Between the stage and the audience, a group of speakers expressed the play’s emotions. In Revelation, the four living creatures have a similar role (Revelation 4:6–8).

The twenty-four elders represent the old and new covenants (4:4). (The “old covenant” refers to the agreement God made with Israel through Moses, which included the Ten Commandments and other laws recorded in the first books of the Bible. The “new covenant” refers to the agreement God made through Jesus Christ, which the New Testament describes as fulfilling the old covenant and establishing a new way of relating to God based on faith in Jesus.) The twenty-four elders act as a chorus with alternating groups of speakers and provide the historical background for this great drama. They also give the historical context for this great drama. God provides the script, and only

his special agent, “the Lamb,” can open, read, and perform it (5:1–5; 6:1).

Passages for Further Study

Revelation 4:1–5:14

The Thousand Years (The Millennium)

A millennium is 1,000 years. Revelation 20 describes the 1,000-year rule of Jesus Christ on earth. Christian groups who highly respect Scripture as God’s inspired and authoritative word have held three views on how this millennium relates to the second coming of Jesus:

1. Premillennialism: The time between Jesus’ first and second comings will end when he returns. He will rule on earth for 1,000 years with his holy people. After this, Jesus will bring final judgment and establish his eternal kingdom. This view places Jesus’ return before (pre-) the millennium.
2. Amillennialism: This is not a literal 1,000-year period. The “1,000 years” is symbolic and represents the current time between Jesus’ first and second comings. During this period, Jesus rules spiritually with his people. At the end of this time, Jesus will return, bring final judgment, and begin his eternal kingdom. This view sees no (a-) separate millennium apart from the current church age.
3. Postmillennialism: During the time between Jesus’ first and second comings, he will extend his rule through the church. This will lead to a long period of peace on earth. This period is the “1,000 years.” At the end of this time, Jesus will return, carry out the final judgment, and establish his eternal kingdom. This view places Jesus’ return after (post-) the millennium.

These different ideas have caused conflict among Christians. Many have abandoned Christian relations with those who hold different opinions. But Christians should show humility and love, not letting these differences divide them. (see 1 Peter 3:8).

The main message of Revelation is that Jesus Christ will physically return and rule a new heaven and earth. A real spiritual battle is happening. Hell, like heaven, is real, and God will judge everyone by his standards. The prophecies of Revelation give hope to God’s people during pain, suffering, and confusion in the world.

Passages for Further Study

Revelation 20:1–10

Tolerance

The apostle Paul urges tolerance (patient understanding) between those weak in faith and those strong in

faith. He teaches Christians to accept each other (Romans 14:1; 15:7). He instructs them to stop condemning one another and making each other feel unimportant. Instead, they should worship God with a united voice and spirit (Romans 15:6).

Paul is discussing whether Christians need to follow certain Old Testament laws and Jewish worship practices. Scholars use the Greek word *adiaphora*, meaning “non-essentials,” to describe beliefs or practices that Scripture neither requires nor bans. On these issues, Christians should accept different opinions. Sometimes, Christians may feel free to do certain activities, but doing so might cause problems for others. In these cases, Paul advises Christians to consider others’ needs before their own (see 1 Corinthians 8:1–13).

Paul uses a different approach to tolerance when the good news (gospel) is at risk. In the letter to the Galatians, for example, Paul confronts false teachings about the good news by strongly criticizing the false teachers (Galatians 1:6–9). He warns readers that accepting false teachings will separate them from Christ (Galatians 5:4).

Today, we must be cautious about what we tolerate and what we oppose. Christians should carefully consider the issues they encounter with other Christians. If we stay true to the basic truth of the good news about Jesus, we should not argue or be divided over less important matters.

Yet, some issues affect the core message of the good news. In these cases, Christians should remain firm and faithful to the good news and to Jesus Christ. Sometimes, it is difficult to determine if an issue is central. It may be important for discussion but not essential for Christian unity. Paul’s approach to various issues in his time can guide us in handling conflicts and arguments today.

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 133:1–3; Romans 12:9–21; 14:1–15:13; 1 Corinthians 1:10; 6:1–20; 8:1–13; 10:1–11:1; 12:12–27; 13:1–8; 2 Corinthians 6:14–7:1; Colossians 3:12–15; 2 Timothy 2:23–26

True Justice

The community of God’s people in Old Testament Israel had to care for widows, orphans, and foreigners (Deuteronomy 27:19). God wanted the Israelites to represent his justice (see 10:17–19). He wanted them to always remember that they had been slaves. He wanted them to remember that they were defenseless in Egypt (see 10:19; 24:18–22). As those who received God’s constant love and faithfulness, how could they

ignore the rights and needs of the weakest among them?

Every society has structures that separate the powerful from the weak and the important from the less important people. This was true for Old Testament Israel, even with its special role as “a holy nation” (Exodus 19:6). Judges and officials were responsible for protecting the law. They might favor those with money, high status, or influence, especially if they offered bribes (Deuteronomy 16:19). Yet, no one can bribe God and he treats all people fairly (10:17). To God, the rich and poor, powerful and weak, honored and desperate are all the same.

The prophets of Israel knew the importance of fairness and justice. They often urged these principles in both community and national life (Isaiah 1:17; 10:1–4; 59:14–19; Ezekiel 22:23–29; Amos 2:6–8; Habakkuk 1:4). The New Testament also commands for fair treatment of the poor and those without advantages. It mentions that God is not pleased when others ignore them (Matthew 23:23; 2 Corinthians 9:6–10; James 2:1–7).

Justice that does not follow God’s standard is not true justice. Those who are unjust will encounter full punishment from the Judge of all the earth (see Deuteronomy 25:13–16).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 23:3; Leviticus 19:15; Deuteronomy 10:17–19; 16:19; 24:12–22; 25:13–16; 27:19; Psalm 82:1–5; Proverbs 11:1; Isaiah 1:17; 10:1–4; 11:3–4; 59:14–19; Jeremiah 22:13–17; Ezekiel 22:23–29; 45:9–10; Amos 2:6–8; 8:5–6; Habakkuk 1:4; Matthew 23:23; Luke 18:6–8; James 2:1–7

True Success

God wants his people to fully commit to him (Deuteronomy 6:4–6; compare Matthew 22:37). True success comes from seeking God and acknowledging him as the ruler, avoiding all false gods (Matthew 6:33; 1 John 5:21). For the people of Israel, success depended on their obedience to God’s covenant (see Leviticus 26:1–46; Deuteronomy 28:1–68). Israel’s spiritual condition and its leaders greatly affected whether they would keep God’s favor and remain in the promised land.

The author of 1–2 Kings starts each ruler’s story with a spiritual evaluation. This often compares each king’s devotion to God with King David’s example (see 1 Kings 11:38; 14:8; 15:3–5, 11). These books show that the future of Israel and Judah depends on their kings’ spiritual leadership. God’s people could only succeed in Canaan if they worshipped God faithfully (see Deuteronomy

12:4-7). The text often criticizes worship of false gods in local places (see, for example, 3:2-4; 11:7).

Starting with King Jeroboam I, the kings of Israel (the northern kingdom) consistently practiced false religion and Scripture criticizes them for it (1 Kings 12:31-32; 13:33-34; 15:25-26, 33-34; 16:11-13, 25-26). Among these kings, King Ahab was the most evil (16:30-33; 21:25-26). His son Ahaziah followed his example and God condemned him for his worship of false gods (22:51-53).

The kings of the northern kingdom led their people toward certain exile (2 Kings 17:21-23). Despite God's repeated attempts to gain their attention, they did not listen (2 Kings 17:13-15, 23). So God gave them the consequences for continuous spiritual unfaithfulness (see 1 Kings 13:33-34).

Some kings of Judah (the southern kingdom) receive praise, but Scripture criticizes many of them. Rehoboam allowed worship of false gods to spread in Judah (1 Kings 14:22-24). Abijam continued his father's sins (15:3). Scripture even criticizes the good kings Asa and Jehoshaphat for allowing popular local worship sites to remain (see 15:14; 22:43). Failing to give God his rightful place led to disastrous results.

The kings and people of the northern kingdom were stupid for doing what they wanted. Yet, the Lord will bless and give true happiness to those who respect and live by his commands (Psalms 33:12; 119:1-2; 144:15). True success comes from recognizing and trusting God as the ruler of one's life (Matthew 6:33). As shown by Jesus and his early followers, success does not always mean having material wealth. Joy and peace come from living by God's will and trusting in him (see Philippians 3:8-14; 1 Peter 4:12-19).

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 6:1-8; 12:4-7; Joshua 1:7-8; 1 Samuel 18:14; 1 Kings 11:38; 12:26-33; 13:1-3, 33-34; 14:8-11; 2 Kings 17:13-23; Psalms 33:12; 119:1-2; 144:15; Matthew 6:33; Luke 10:25-28; 1 John 5:21

Trusting God in Isaiah

The prophet Isaiah knew that humans can be unreliable (Isaiah 2:22). When in trouble, the people of Judah often asked other nations like Egypt or Assyria for help. Yet, Isaiah explained that Judah's success and safety depended on trusting God (see Isaiah 8:9-17). The Assyrian army made fun of King Hezekiah for trusting God, but this trust led to a great victory for God's people (Isaiah 36:1-37:37).

Those who trust in the Lord feel deep respect for him and do not fear (29:23; 35:4). This is because they know the Lord is with them (51:12). They praise him because they trust him (12:1-2; 25:9). They show their trust by obeying him (26:8).

The faithful people of God may experience the effects of his judgment on his enemies as they wait for the Lord's salvation. Yet, they gain new strength each day (40:31). They consider themselves citizens of God's city, Zion (see 26:1-3). Those who trust in the Lord have true and lasting inner peace (26:3, 12; 32:17-18).

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 2:22; 7:4-9; 8:16-20; 12:1-2; 26:2-3, 12; 32:17-18; 35:4; 40:9-11, 28-31; 51:12

Trusting God in the Psalms

The Lord's love inspires people to trust him (Psalms 13:5; 17:7; 21:7; 32:10; 36:7; 52:8; 143:8). His name and reputation also build trust (9:10; 20:7; 33:21). Godly people avoid worshiping false gods and anything that makes their complete trust in the Lord weak (31:6, 14; 44:6; 49:6-13; 52:7). Trusting the Lord is wise. It rejects what is stupid and evil and follows the spiritual way of the Lord (31:19; 37:3, 5; 115:11).

For godly people, every challenge in life is a chance to grow in trust (Psalms 9:9; 25:2; 46:1; 55:23; 57:1; 59:16; 62:8; 78:7). Godly people do not fear life's situations (56:3-4, 11; 112:7). Instead they become more confident during them (112:7; 125:1).

The Lord saves, cares for, and rewards those who trust in him (see Psalms 7:1; 16:1; 25:20; 26:1; 31:1-2, 4, 19; 34:22; 37:39-40; 86:2). God blesses them as they hope for God's redemption (2:12; 22:4-5; 34:8; 40:4; 84:12; 37:7, 34; 38:15; 40:1; 119:166; 130:5-6). Faith in the Lord brings joy and reasons to praise him (5:11; 18:30-36; 28:7; 40:3; 56:4; 64:10).

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 7:1; 9:9; 11:1; 18:30-36; 22:4-5, 8-9; 25:1-3, 20; 26:1; 28:7; 31:1-6; 34:8-10; 37:3-9; 40:1-4; 46:1; 56:3-4, 11; 62:1-12; 64:10; 78:7; 84:12; 86:2; 112:7; 115:9-11; 119:42; 125:1; 130:5-6; 141:8; Proverbs 3:5; 22:19; Isaiah 26:4; 40:31; Jeremiah 17:7; Hebrews 10:35

Trusting in Human Strength

God often showed his power to his people throughout their history. He made an elderly couple, who could not have children, the ancestors of a great nation. He saved this nation from the powerful ruler of Egypt. He performed many miracles to help them survive in the wilderness.

He also won victories over their enemies many times during the conquest, the time of the judges, and the period of kings. Yet, throughout their history, the people of Israel often did not trust the Lord. They chose to rely on human strength instead.

Once, Asa, King of Judah, asked the king of Aram for help. Aram was a long-time enemy of God's people. Asa gave him treasures from the temple and palace so he would attack Baasha, King of Israel (2 Chronicles 16:1-6). The prophet Hanani criticized Asa, warning that Aram would remain an enemy to Judah. Past battles showed that Asa only needed God as support (16:8).

Asa's dependence on the king of Aram showed a deeper spiritual issue. Asa forgot that "the eyes of the LORD roam to and fro over all the earth" (2 Chronicles 16:9; see also Zechariah 4:10). When Hanani showed Asa his mistakes, Asa quickly put the prophet in prison. The angry king also unfairly harmed the people (2 Chronicles 16:10).

Asa shows how people often rely on their own resources and get angry when corrected (see Proverbs 11:7; Isaiah 31:1; Jeremiah 17:5-6). Even those who have seen the Lord's power can act this way. This was true for the Israelites rescued from slavery in Egypt. It is better to trust the Lord and accept his guidance (compare Psalms 33:18; 37:7; Isaiah 50:10; Jeremiah 17:7-8; Acts 13:43).

Life teaches us to trust God. We might start by doing good and right (2 Chronicles 14:1-6). But our spiritual impact is not complete until our last action (see Romans 2:6-11; 1 Corinthians 4:1-5). We must not let personal ambitions make weak our faithfulness to God's kingdom.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 13:4; 2 Kings 6:15-18; 2 Chronicles 16:1-10; 32:7-8; Psalms 20:6-8; 37:3-7; 60:11-12; Proverbs 11:7-8; 18:10-12; Ecclesiastes 3:14; Isaiah 31:1-5; Jeremiah 17:5-8; Matthew 10:26-31; Romans 2:6-11; 1 Corinthians 4:1-5; Revelation 2:8-11